ARMOR
by nate langley

In the mornings at my grandparents' house the light came up over the fields gray and by then my grandmother was already at the stove. Bacon in the black skillet and the radio low on the windowsill. My grandfather sat at the table with his coffee and his two hands laid flat on the oilcloth. I came in barefoot across the cold tile. As I passed, my grandmother touched the back of my neck and said nothing.

Something had been coming in the night. The old man walked the rows at dawn and found the potato hills dug out and the melons torn open in the furrows like small things murdered in their sleep. He knelt and put two fingers in a track and came back up to the house wiping his hand on his trousers.

Armadillo, he said. *They'll root up a whole garden in a week.*

He drank his coffee and looked at me. *You ever shot a gun?*

I shook my head.

He nodded as if he had long known it and wanted only to hear it said aloud.

Well, he spoke. *Reckon it's time you did.*

In the evening he took the rifle down from the rack in the shed. A .22 with the stock gone dark from the oil of hands. On the porch he showed me the bolt and where the cartridges went and how the safety sat under the thumb. The cartridges were small and bright.

Put it tight in your shoulder, he said. *Like it's part of you. Don't pull the trigger. Squeeze it. Breathe out and squeeze.*

Yes sir.

We walked out at dusk along the edge of the field where the treeline came down black against the sky and the heat of the day still rose out of the ground. Crickets starting up in the ditch grass. He walked ahead and did not speak as I carried the rifle in my arms that were much too small for it. We sat in the weeds at the end of a row and waited.

It came out of the trees when there was almost no light left to see it. Nose to the ground in a shuffling trot. Plated and banded like some beast from an older world, small and absurd and ancient all at once. Its kind had walked this continent the size of giants when there was no one here to name them. Now it went snuffling among the potato hills tracing the floor like a man tracking something he lost.

He touched my arm. *Go on*, he whispered. *Aim for the neck.*

I brought the rifle up, but it did not feel like part of me. It felt like what it was. I laid my cheek to its cool stock and found the animal along the barrel in the gray. It was so small out there and it did not know I was in the world at all. I breathed out. I squeezed.

The sound was smaller than I had thought it would be. The armadillo leapt straight up the way they do and came down on its side and then it was going around and around in the dirt with its legs working at nothing. It thrashed and rolled and righted itself and fell again and I could see the

blood black in the dusk where it came from the soft place under the armor and the dry ground drinking it. Still it went on, still trying to go somewhere, its small feet raking the furrow. Then it slowed. Then it lay on its side with its ribs going and its feet moving a little as if it ran in some dream of running.

Again, he said. *Go on. Again.*

I could not. My hands were not my own. I stood and watched the animal breathe and I could hear it now, a small wet sound, and he said my name once and still I did not move.

Then his hands were on the rifle. He did not take it roughly. He took it the way you would take a glass from the hand of someone sleeping. He worked the bolt and stepped into the row and put the muzzle near its head and fired and the small body jerked once and was still.

The crickets had stopped. And then they started again.

He carried it by the tail to the ditch and laid it in the grass and we walked up to the house in the dark without speaking. My grandmother was at the sink. She turned and looked at my face and then at him and then she turned back to the sink.

That night I lay in the narrow bed in the back room and went over it and over it. I had been weighed in the balance and found wanting. Whatever door had opened to me that evening had shut and would not open twice. Out in the ditch the thing laid in its armor in the wet grass and I could not stop seeing its feet going.

I am older now. I have been a long way from that country.

When I look back I see myself the way you see a figure on a far ridge at evening. I know the shape of it. I have tried to go back and stand where I stood and it is not the same ground.

Back then I believed the test was the first shot. I believed he wanted to see me pull a trigger and stand like a man while something died at my feet, and that I had been found unequal to it. I carried that a long time. Longer than I like to say.

But I have turned it over since and I don't believe that anymore. It took growing up to see him as a man and not as the judge I had made of him. A man with his own father somewhere behind him and his own field at dusk. Somebody had put a gun in his hands once and told him what it would make of him and he had believed it because what else was there to believe. He was handing me what had been handed him. It was the only thing he had been given to give.

And I see the other thing. When the animal lay there in its blood and I could not move it was he who stepped forward. Who would not let a living thing go on suffering for the sake of a lesson. I thought he took the rifle because I had failed it. I think now he took it because he saw it was more than I could carry so he would not make me carry it alone.

I don't know if it made me a man. I don't know what that word meant to him and I am less sure every year what it means to me.

When I think of him now I don't think of the rifle. I think of the kitchen in the morning before any of it. The radio low on the sill. My grandmother's hand on the back of my neck. And my grandfather at the table with his coffee and his two hands laid flat on the oilcloth. The same hands. Resting there as if they had never done a wrong thing in this world.